BOOKS

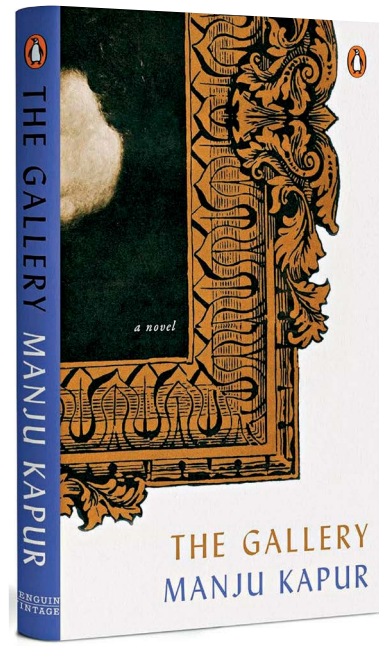
CLASS ACT

The worlds of art and relationships intertwine in **Manju Kapur**'s new novel, *The Gallery*

Four lives are woven skilfully around an art gallery in Manju Kapur's quietly brilliant seventh novel. Minal, educated and idealistic with her baby, Ellora; Maitrye (Matti), uneducated and unskilled with her baby, Tashi. Then there's La Galleri itself, a potential space, where commerce and creativity clink wine glasses in the presence of what may or may not be great art.

Minal's husband Alok Sinha is a corporate lawyer and Matti's husband Krisna is Alok's fiercely ambitious peon. But the men are mere plot devices in a narrative sculpted by the four main characters and the patterns of tension created by the other women in their lives. Instead of languishing in the trough of two failed romances, Minal accepts an "arranged love" marriage with a peevish, ailing mother-in-law on the ground floor and a garden overhead, on the terrace of a posh Golf Links flat. When she decides to open an art gallery, her mother insists she needs a baby-minder. Minal angrily reveals that when she was a child, her female "minder" was abusive. Whereupon her mother bursts into tears, refusing to believe her.

Then a Nepali village girl with no choices other than mute acceptance, arrives on the arm of a husband she barely knows, in a city where she does not speak the language. She's pushed into looking after another woman's baby while still nursing her own child. Kapur's triumph is in showing us what can happen when a fictional character pushes past her own familiar, well-worn prejudices in favour of the idealism and compassion she learnt in university. Matti is described with the same care and detail as Minal, but from the other side of the class divide. We watch a warm but realistic drama of haves and have-nots play out within a household where both little girls grow into adulthood side by side. The world might discriminate between them, but the author treats them with equal respect. It's wonderful exactly because it's so rare.



THE GALLERY
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The descriptions of journeys outside India are a treat, particularly the Antarctic cruise. Equally polished are the scenes and events connected to art. Minal is described as someone who has studied the subject without being especially artistic herself. Through her mistakes, we gain an appreciation of the 'Business of Art'. While she learns to navigate around the egos of artists, charlatans and patrons to provide a genuine service to the world, we catch glimpses of the sublime and the prosaic, peeking out from Kapur's prose.

With all that is genuine, some false notes become inevitable. For instance, a pair of marital excursions flicker in and out of existence so swiftly as to seem like fashion accessories rather than honest-to-goodness affairs. Minal's relationship with Alok, interestingly prickly at the outset, slouches into "who cares?" territory towards the end. Perhaps art and heart do not co-exist easily after all! Or so we might conclude. ■

–Manjula Padmanabhan